

of the basis of Kott system rather than Ket (Starostin Georgii 1995: 158–159).¹⁰ Therefore, it provides us further justification to believe that matches between Xiong-nu and Proto-Yeniseian morphology are not chance resemblances.

I, therefore, come to the following interpretation and translation of the Xiong-nu poem that closely follows the Chinese translation:

秀支替戾岡，僕谷劬禿當。

*suke t-i-r-ek-ang bok-kok k-o-t-o-kt-ang

armies PV-CM-PERF-go out-3pp bok-kok PV-?-OBJ-CM-catch-3pp
(PV – preverb, CM – conjugation marker, OBJ – object marker,
PERF – perfective)

秀支，軍也。替戾岡，出也。僕谷，劉曜胡位也。劬禿當，捉也
Armies have gone out. [They] will catch *bok-kok*.

Note that 3pp subject agreement marker -ang on both verbs requires interpreting the word *suke as plural “armies” rather than singular “army.” As was mentioned above, the Chinese translation does not provide any clue as to whether Shi Le had one army or several armies involved in his campaign against Liu Yao. However, the small passage immediately preceding the passage quoted above does:

劉曜遣從弟岳攻勒，勒遣石季龍拒之。岳敗，退保石梁塢，季龍堅柵守之。澄在襄國，忽歎曰：「劉岳可憫！」弟子法祚問其故，澄曰：「昨日亥時，岳已敗被執。」果如所言。

Liu Yao sent his second younger brother [Liu] Yue to attack [Shi] Le, and [Shi] Le sent Shi Jilong to deter him. [Liu] Yue defeated [Shi] Jilong, and [the latter] retreated to the protection of Shi Liang's stockade. [Shi] Jilong strongly defended the fence. Cheng was [at that time] in Xiang country and said with a sigh: “I pity [Liu] Yue!” When his disciple Fazuo asked him about the reason of this, Cheng replied: “Yesterday, at the hour of the boar, Yue

¹⁰ Verner believes that the Arin and Pumpokol languages constitute a subgroup within Yeniseian (1997a: 171). On the other hand, Kott, according to Verner, is in a different subgroup with the Assan language (1997a: 171). Thus, we have two independent pieces of evidence for the archaic nature of Kott subject agreement.